

Chapter 158-1

Gu Xingyue sat there in a daze for a long time.

She had thought that after experiencing so much, she should be able to remain calm and unfazed.

Yet after Liang Shi spoke those words with such certainty, her emotions still surged.

After a moment, Gu Xingyue finally said slowly: "Let me think about it."

She didn't give a definite answer.

Gu Xingyue lowered her head and took a sip of water, her hands resting on the warm cup. Her gaze passed through the clean floor-to-ceiling windows, watching the surging crowd outside.

Her eyes were hazy and vacant, making it impossible to tell what she was thinking.

After a long while, Gu Xingyue stood up. "I'll be going now."

Liang Shi stood up as well. "Okay."

When she reached the door, Gu Xingyue suddenly stopped and turned back a few steps, her voice very soft. "Could you let me see the test report?"

"I'll ask my friend." Liang Shi said. "To see if she can take a photo and send it to me."

"Okay." Gu Xingyue paused. "Send it to my WeChat when you get it."

Liang Shi was startled. She was just about to ask if she was still using that account when she saw Gu Xingyue open her phone, pull up a QR code, and push it in front of her.

Liang Shi immediately scanned it.

After Gu Xingyue left, Liang Shi drove around aimlessly for a while.

Driving without any destination.

In the end, she unknowingly drove to the entrance of their residential complex.

On the Yujiang Bridge, traffic still flowed like shuttles. The water in the Yujiang River flowed slowly beneath the thin layer of ice.

Nothing had changed.

When the car pulled over to the side of the road, she still found it hard to believe and smiled bitterly to herself.

Then she tilted her head up to look at the high-rise.

After a while, her neck started to ache, and only then did she lower her head.

Liang Shi curled her fingers and lightly tapped the steering wheel. The rhythmic tapping sound seemed to be giving herself courage. She didn't know how long this went on—it seemed like a very long time—before she finally grabbed her coat from the back seat, casually slipped it on, stretched out her long arm, and pushed open the car door.

The biting winter wind instantly penetrated her skin, pouring in through her collar, making her shiver from the cold.

It had only been a few days since she'd been back, yet she felt a sense of apprehension about returning home.¹

Liang Shi pulled her coat collar tight and walked quickly to the entrance of the apartment building.

The first floor had the usual mailbox area. She found their unit's compartment, entered the password, and opened it—it was completely empty inside.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't put the divorce agreement in the storage compartment downstairs, nor had she contacted her.

As if she hadn't seen her message at all.

But she had disappeared for so many days with her phone turned off—Xu Qingzhu couldn't possibly not have noticed.

So the most likely possibility was that she was avoiding it.

Liang Shi couldn't figure out what Xu Qingzhu was thinking.

She had thought she understood Xu Qingzhu very well.

But at a time like this, Xu Qingzhu's behavior once again exceeded her expectations.

Liang Shi had only guessed two possible outcomes: either she would call to question her, or she would sign the divorce agreement and leave it downstairs.

But it was neither.

Xu Qingzhu acted as if she didn't know about this matter, continuing to go to and from work normally, and hadn't contacted her again.

In the past, they had contacted each other very frequently, sending many messages almost every day.

Even when she was filming.

Except for those few days when Xu Qingzhu first started having nightmares, they sent slightly fewer messages, but still about twenty-something each day.

Just casual chatting or idle talk—they would send messages.

Not like now, where they had tacitly cut off contact.

Yet without mentioning the divorce matter again.

Liang Shi sat on the bench downstairs, and after much deliberation, she still sent Xu Qingzhu a message: 【I came to get the divorce agreement. You didn't put it in the cabinet downstairs. What's going on?】

Even looking at it through the screen, it was a very harsh-sounding message, appearing somewhat cold.

After just a moment, the note at the top of Xu Qingzhu's chat box changed to "The other party is typing."

Then Liang Shi watched as "Zhuzi" and "The other party is typing" kept alternating. After about ten minutes of this, Liang Shi finally received a reply.

Xu Qingzhu: 【I'm considering it.】

Liang Shi: ...

Xu Qingzhu sent another message: 【Don't you want to meet and talk about this?】

Liang Shi: ...

Although separated by a screen, Liang Shi could already picture Xu Qingzhu's cold eyes in her mind. She would look over coldly, and her already cool voice combined with her indifferent tone would probably make Liang Shi feel like she had gone back to when she first transmigrated and met her.

No, perhaps it would be even worse than that.

It was very clear: Xu Qingzhu was angry.

But Liang Shi had no choice.

She didn't want to discuss this topic with Xu Qingzhu face to face. If Xu Qingzhu got angry, she would feel terrified. If Xu Qingzhu cried, she might soften. But a decision had to be made—hesitating would only hurt people more deeply. It was better to cut through the mess quickly.

That was why Liang Shi had left alone that morning.

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1. The phrase "近乡情怯" (jìn xiāng qíng qiè) is a Chinese idiom meaning "the closer one gets to home, the more anxious one becomes." It describes the mixed feelings of nervousness, apprehension, and emotional turmoil one experiences when returning home after a long absence, often due to uncertainty about what changes may have occurred or how one will be received. ⇐